

PREM SINGH TAMANG
Chief Minister, Sikkim

"Our GDP is Rs 52,555 crore; our per capita income is the highest in India. With the blessings of the Indian government, we'll do a lot more work, so that Sikkim sets an example of how even a small state can achieve greatness"

"Now our literacy rate is over 90 per cent. We want to become a fully literate state by 2027.... Our vision is to establish one university in every constituency so that our students do not have to go outside the state. We aim to create an ecosystem where they get world-class education at home"

"We are fourth in terms of poverty alleviation. We will work to make Sikkim poverty-free.... We want to continue as a model for environmental protection, inclusive growth and innovation"

The INDIA TODAY State of the States—Sikkim@50 conclave, held in New Delhi on May 22, marked 50 years since the Himalayan state's accession to the Indian Union. Addressing the gathering, Chief Minister Prem Singh Tamang—re-elected with a near-total mandate last year—hailed the moment as historic not just for Sikkim, but for the nation.

Tamang outlined three core governance priorities: national security, connectivity and human development. He cited the transfer of the Sevoke-Rangpo stretch of the NH-10 from West Bengal to the central authority and upcoming railway connectivity by 2026 as transformative for trade and tourism.

On health, he shared that dialysis services have now reached every district hospital, cancer treatment has begun in the state, and a new 500-bed referral hospital is set to be inaugurated by Prime Minister Narendra Modi on May 29. Education, aligned early with the National Education Policy, is also central. The state already has a literacy rate exceeding 90 per cent, and the government aims for universal literacy by 2027. Tamang also envisions at least one university in every constituency to stem youth migration. His flagship 'One Family, One Entrepreneur' scheme has disbursed Rs 240 crore in collateral-free loans to over 25,000 applicants, fostering grassroots enterprise. Environmental stewardship remains core to Sikkim's identity. The 'Mero Rukh, Mero Santati' (My Tree, My Family) scheme links afforestation with financial security for newborns.

The conclave also featured insights on strategic policy, sustainable development and Sikkim's vision for 2047. From women changemakers to educationists, from MPs, ministers and top officials to entrepreneurs and football icon Bhaichung Bhutia, the event showcased a 50-year-young state determined to scale new heights.

—ARKAMOY DATTA MAJUMDAR

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